Ford Motor Company

James P. Vondale, Director
Automotive Safety Office
Environmental & Safety Engineering

March 2, 2001

Mr. Kenneth N. Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein:

Re: Ford Recall No. 01S09 – 2000 Model Year Taurus/Sable and Excursion Headlamp Switch Knob Fracture and Separation

Summary

- Ford Action – Ford is conducting a voluntary safety recall involving 2000 model year Ford Taurus and Mercury Sable Passenger Cars and Ford Excursion MPVs. These vehicles were built from October 8, 1999 through December 6, 1999.

- Number of Vehicles Involved -- Approximately 74,000 vehicles.

- Affect on Vehicle Operation – Due to the use of incorrect material by a second tier supplier, the headlamp switch knob may fracture and separate from the headlamp switch potentially making it difficult for the driver to activate the headlamps. Although Ford does not believe that this condition presents an unreasonable risk to motor vehicle safety, Ford has decided as a precaution to conduct this action as if it were safety related.

- Service Procedure -- Dealers will replace the headlamp switch knob with a new knob that is made of the intended material.

Attached is the detailed information required by the applicable portions of 49 CFR Part 573 -- Defect and Non-Compliance Information Report.

Sincerely,

James P. Vondale

Attachment
01S09 5d/rjw/ae

ATTACHMENT

49 CFR Part 573 -- DEFECT INFORMATION REPORT
01S09 - 2000 MODEL YEAR TAURUS/SABLE AND EXCURSION
HEADLAMP KNOB FRACTURE AND SEPARATION

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, Ford Motor Company submits the following information concerning a safety recall action that it is voluntarily initiating.

573.5 (c) (2) -- Potentially Affected Vehicles

Certain 2000 model year Ford Taurus and Mercury Sable passenger cars and Ford Excursion multi-purpose passenger vehicles (MPV) built at the Chicago Assembly, Atlanta Assembly and Kentucky Truck Plants from October 8, 1999 through December 6, 1999 are potentially affected.

Because these vehicles are not produced in VIN order, information as to the applicability of this action to specific vehicles can best be obtained by either calling Ford's toll-free line (1-800-392-3673) or contacting a local Ford dealer, who can obtain specific information regarding the vehicles from the Ford On-line Automotive Service Information System (OASIS) database.

The headlamp switch knobs noted later in this report were supplied to Ford by TRW Automotive Electronics, 23855 Research Drive, Farmington Hills, MI 48335. TRW's phone number is (248) 442-5363.

573.5 (c) (3) -- Estimated Population of Vehicles Potentially Affected

Approximately 74,000 vehicles.

573.5 (c) (4) -- Estimated Percentage of Affected Vehicles with the Defect Condition

Unknown.

573.5 (c) (5) --Description of the Defect

The headlamp switch knob on the affected vehicles may have been molded from a plastic material that is more brittle than the intended material. This material may be overstressed when the knob is installed on the switch, leading to a later fracture, and in some cases, separation of the knob from the headlamp switch. If the knob separates from the switch, it may be difficult for the driver to activate the headlamps. Although Ford does not believe that this condition presents an unreasonable risk to motor vehicle safety, Ford has decided as a precaution to conduct this action as if it were safety related.

Ford is aware of approximately 1,200 reports of headlamp switch knobs separating from the headlamp switch on the subject vehicles. A review of reports did not locate any that alleged that an accident or injury occurred.

573.5 (c) (6) -- Chronology of Events

Ford first began receiving reports of fractured headlamp switch knobs in mid-2000. Ford was notified by TRW during December 2000 that knobs had been molded of an unintended material by a second tier supplier. Subsequent investigation established the suspect population.

573.5 (c) (8) -- Service Program

Ford will notify owners of record of affected vehicles to return vehicles to dealers for installation of a headlamp switch knob made of the intended material. This service will be performed at no charge to owners. Ford currently anticipates that owner notification will occur on or before the week of March 26, 2001.

573.5 (c) (9) -- Press statement and Dealer/Owner Letters

Ford does not plan to make a public statement concerning this action. Notices to dealers and owners from Ford Customer Service Division will be forwarded when available.

573.5 (c) (11) -- Recall Number

Ford has assigned recall number 01S09 to this action.